

TAPPING HAPPINESS
A reservoir constructed under the Ganga Water Supply Scheme in Rajgir

The Curse Turned Blessing

Bihar comes up with a first-of-its-kind project to tap into and supply Ganga's floodwater from its northern districts to the parched southern regions

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GANGA WATER SUPPLY SCHEME
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Every monsoon, Bihar finds itself in a peculiar quandary. Just when the state's northern districts are grappling with floods due to the overflowing Himalayan rivers that drain into the mighty Ganga, affecting more than two million families year after year, about 20 districts in the south found themselves trapped in a drought-like situation. The reasons for water deficiency are aplenty: smaller feeding rivers in the south, except the Son; rocky or sandy soil; and irregular rains, to list a few.

One morning in late 2018, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar, an engineer-turned-politician, was discussing the issue with a select group of bureaucrats and politicians, when he came up with an idea. How about engineering a system that could treat and transport floodwater from the state's northern plains to its drought-prone areas in the south?

But when the water resources department started its research to turn the CM's idea into a practicable solution, there was not a single precedent to be found across India. Then, in June 2019, Nitish expanded his cabinet, assigning the water resources portfolio to his close confidant Sanjay Jha. Subsequently, an agreement was stitched up with Hyderabad-based Megha Engineering and Infrastructures Limited (MEIL) to take the project to fruition.

The aim was to draw the excess Ganga water during the four monsoon months (June-September), and store and treat it for the year-round supply of potable water to the historical cities of Rajgir (Nalanda district), Gaya and Bodh Gaya (Gaya district), situated about 90-130 kilometres south of state capital Patna. The core of the ancient Magadha empire with links to the founders of both Buddhism and Jainism, it is among the most parched regions in Bihar, where the locals, stuck with dried hand pumps for most of the year, have to call in water tankers from adjoining districts.

But bringing the surplus Ganga water to the region was easier said than done, admits water resources secretary Sanjay Agarwal. If the two Covid-19 waves in 2020 and 2021 slowed down the project's progress, there were even bigger engineering challenges to overcome. Tapping the floodwater was one thing, but then transporting it over an undulating topography while making way through the existing